

Marfa, Texas: Art In The Desert [B2]

Un tempo avamposto militare e terra di cowboy, dagli anni '70 questa città nel cuore del deserto texano è una meta imprescindibile per gli amanti dell'arte minimalista.

At the heart of West Texas' Chihuahuan Desert lies an unlikely oasis of contemporary art: the town of Marfa. Once a sleepy outpost split in two by a railway line and populated largely by ranchers and cowboys, Marfa might have remained one of many forgotten desert towns. Instead, in the early 1970s, it underwent a remarkable transformation, becoming an international symbol of artistic renewal when the minimalist sculptor Donald Judd fell under its spell.

DESERT LANDSCAPES

At the height of his fame, Judd made the radical decision to leave New York. He saw in Marfa's desert landscapes an ideal setting for his monumental, permanent installations. At the time, Marfa resembled the ghost towns so common in the American Southwest, consisting of only a handful of ranches and adobe houses, many without running water or electricity. Undeterred, Judd purchased several buildings after moving there with his family, including former military warehouses that he converted into spaces to house his personal collection. This collection included not only his own work, but also pieces by close friends and collaborators — the very cream of Minimalism. 100 Untitled Works in Mill Aluminum (1982-1986), a permanent installation at The Chinati Foundation in Marfa, Texas.

RAW BEAUTY

Artists and collectors followed Judd to Marfa, drawn by both his vision and the town's raw, elemental beauty. The town soon gained an almost mythical reputation worldwide. Nearly fifty years later, Marfa continues to exert the same magnetic pull, particularly on New Yorkers seeking an escape from city

life. Many arrive for long weekends, only to find themselves [lingering](#) longer than planned. The town is known for its [bewitching](#) quality: [sparse](#) yet vibrating with creative energy. Places

Bats: The Original Tourist Attraction Of Austin, Texas Austin ospita la più grande colonia di pipistrelli del Nordamerica. Il loro volo è uno spettacolo magico che si ripete ogni sera, da marzo a novembre. Chuck Rolando

EMPTINESS AND ART

Although fewer than two thousand people live there permanently, Marfa [teems with](#) art galleries, studios, and [thoughtfully](#) curated restaurants, and even [boasts](#) its own radio station. Among the [must-see spots](#) are Ballroom Marfa, a contemporary art centre that [doubles as](#) a concert hall and movie theatre, and the Wrong Store, a cooperative space that exhibits and sells works by local artists, [embodying](#) the town's collaborative spirit. Every year in May, Marfa also hosts a festival, the Invitational, a weekend-long festival dedicated to contemporary art. The festival combines an art fair with activities such as conversations with artists. Founded in 2019 by artist and curator Michael Phelan and his wife, art advisor Melissa Bent — both residents of Marfa —, the Invitational has quickly become a key moment in the town's cultural calendar, reinforcing Marfa's status as a small town with an [outsize](#) influence on the global art world.

Glossary

- **sparse** = rada
- **teems with** = pullulare di
- **thoughtfully** = con cura
- **boasts** = vantare
- **unlikely** = inaspettata
- **underwent** = attraversare
- **At the height of** = all'apice di
- **handful** = manciata
- **purchased** = acquistare
- **must-see spots** = luoghi imperdibili
- **outsize** = smisurata
- **sleepy** = assonnato
- **outpost** = avamposto
- **fell under its spell** = cadere sotto il suo incantesimo
- **Undeterred** = imperterrito
- **raw** = grezza
- **exert** = esercitare
- **bewitching** = incantevole
- **lies** = trovarsi
- **house** = ospitare
- **pull** = attrazione
- **lingering** = trattenersi
- **doubles as** = fungere anche da
- **embodying** = incarnare
- **split in two** = dividere in due
- **running water** = acqua corrente
- **warehouses** = magazzini
- **drawn** = attirare